

IS IT A SCAM?

SOUTH AFRICA'S TOP 20 SCAMS

How each one runs, what gives it away, and what to do if
it has already happened.

A FREE BRIEFING DECK • 32 SCAMS DOCUMENTED AT ISITASCAM.CO.ZA

BEFORE WE START

HOW TO USE THIS DECK

THE POINT IS NOT MEMORISATION

Twenty scams is too many to remember under pressure. What you are learning is the shape they share, so that scam twenty-one is recognisable the first time you meet it.

EVERY ONE OF THESE HAS THREE PARTS

Contact you did not ask for. Pressure to act before you check. A payment method that cannot be reversed. Watch for those three across all twenty.

THE TWO RULES TO LEAVE WITH

- **Nobody legitimate ever asks for your OTP, PIN or password.**
- **You never pay a fee to receive money.**

NAVIGATE

Arrow keys or swipe to move. Press  or use your browser's print dialog to save the whole deck as a PDF.

SIX QUESTIONS THAT EXPOSE ALMOST ANYTHING

1 Who started this?

They found you.

2 Why must this happen right now?

Urgency is manufactured to stop you thinking.

3 How am I being asked to pay?

Irreversible payment methods are chosen deliberately.

4 What are they asking me to reveal or install?

Nobody legitimate needs your OTP, PIN or your screen.

5 Can I verify this on a channel they did not give me?

Verification only counts if you choose the channel.

6 Does the money make sense?

Ask where the profit actually comes from, and insist on an answer.

Three or more hits means stop and verify on a channel they did not give you.

FAKE BANK SMS & EMAIL PHISHING

A text or email that looks like it came from your bank warns of a suspicious transaction and pushes you to a cloned login page or a phone number staffed by the criminals.

89

SEVERE THREAT

R3 000-R250 000

HOW IT RUNS

1. **The bait lands.** You get an SMS, WhatsApp or email: a R4 999 purchase at a store you have never used, a new beneficiary added, or your profile 'locked'.
2. **A single urgent action.** The message gives you exactly one thing to do: click the link to reverse it, or call the number in the message.
3. **The cloned front door.** The link opens a pixel-accurate copy of your bank's login page on a lookalike domain.
4. **The OTP harvest.** The real bank sends you a genuine OTP because a real transaction is being attempted.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- The message contains a link. Real banks tell you to use the app you already have.
- You are asked to phone a number printed inside the message rather than the one on your card.
- Anyone asks you to read out, forward or type an OTP, PIN or full card number.
- The domain is nearly right but not right: extra words, hyphens, or an unusual ending.

WHAT TO DO

- Treat every unexpected bank message as fake until you prove otherwise. Never click, never call the number in the message.
- Open the bank's own app, or phone the number physically printed on your bank card, and ask them directly.
- Memorise this: no legitimate bank employee will ever ask you for an OTP, PIN or password. There is no exception to this rule.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/banking-sms-phishing/

SIM SWAP FRAUD

Criminals convince your mobile network to move your number onto a SIM card they hold, which hands them every OTP your bank sends.

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HIGH THREAT

R10 000–R500 000

HOW IT RUNS

1. **Your details are gathered first.** A SIM swap is the second half of an attack.
2. **The swap is requested.** Posing as you, they ask your network to port the number to a new SIM, sometimes through a bribed or careless store agent.
3. **Your phone goes dark.** Your handset loses signal and shows 'No service' or 'SIM not provisioned'.
4. **The OTPs arrive on their phone.** Every verification code your bank sends now lands with the criminal.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Your phone suddenly loses all network signal for no reason, especially at night or over a weekend.
- You stop receiving calls and SMSes while data over Wi-Fi still works fine.
- An unexpected message from your network saying a SIM swap or port has been requested.
- Friends say your number is ringing but you never see the calls.

WHAT TO DO

- Move off SMS OTPs wherever you can. Use your bank's in-app approval or an authenticator app instead.
- Ask your network to place a port-out or SIM-swap lock on your number, with a passphrase only you know.
- Treat sudden, unexplained loss of signal as an emergency, not an inconvenience. Verify on another phone immediately.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/sim-swap-fraud/

PROPERTY DEPOSIT & INVOICE REDIRECTION

Criminals sit inside an email conversation between you and your attorney, estate agent or supplier, then send a genuine-looking invoice with their own bank account on it.



HOW IT RUNS

1. **An inbox is compromised.** Usually not yours.
2. **They wait for the money moment.** The criminal reads the thread until a large payment is imminent.
3. **The switch.** You receive what appears to be the same invoice or letter, on the right letterhead, in the right thread, with correct references.
4. **You pay, correctly, to the wrong people.** Nothing about the transaction is technically fraudulent from the bank's point of view.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Any change of banking details, ever, for any reason. This is the single defining red flag.
- A new email address that differs by one character from the one you have been using.
- A request to keep the payment 'urgent and confidential' or to pay before a deadline expires.
- An invoice sent as a PDF you did not expect, or a re-sent invoice 'because the first one had an error'.

WHAT TO DO

- Establish banking details once, verbally, at the start of the relationship, and write them down yourself. Then refuse to change them under any circumstance.
- Before any large payment, phone the recipient on a number you already had, never a number from the email, and read the account number back to them digit by digit.
- Send a R1 test payment first and confirm receipt verbally before sending the balance.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/conveyancing-invoice-redirection/

CRYPTO & FOREX INVESTMENT SCAMS

A polished platform or a persuasive 'mentor' shows you profits that do not exist, then blocks your withdrawal behind an endless queue of fees.

89

SEVERE THREAT

R20 000–R2 000 000

HOW IT RUNS

1. **Warm contact, not cold.** It rarely starts with an investment pitch.
2. **Trust is built patiently.** Weeks of ordinary conversation.
3. **A small deposit that works.** You put in R2 000.
4. **The numbers climb.** You deposit more.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Guaranteed or unusually consistent returns. Real markets do not produce smooth upward lines.
- You must pay a fee, tax or deposit before you can withdraw your own profits. This is definitional fraud.
- The 'opportunity' reached you through a stranger's DM, a wrong number, or a dating app.
- Celebrity endorsement in a video ad. Deepfaked local business figures are heavily used in South Africa.

WHAT TO DO

- Check the FSCA register before you send a cent. If the firm is not licensed to give financial advice in South Africa, stop there.
- Apply the withdrawal test early: try to take out a meaningful amount before you ever deposit a meaningful amount.
- Understand that any legitimate investment deducts fees from your balance. It never asks you to send new money to release old money.

Full breakdown:
isitascam.co.za/scams/crypto-investment-scam/

PONZI & PYRAMID SCHEMES

Early participants are paid with money from later participants, not from any real trading or business, until recruitment slows and the whole structure collapses.

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SEVERE THREAT

R5 000–R1 500 000

HOW IT RUNS

1. **It arrives through someone you trust.**
Not a stranger.
2. **The early payouts are real.** The first cohort genuinely gets paid, in full, on time.
3. **Recruitment becomes the product.**
Returns are explicitly or quietly tied to how many people you bring in.
4. **Reinvestment is encouraged.** Members are pushed to roll profits back in rather than withdraw.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Returns depend on recruiting others, however it is dressed up.
- Fixed high returns quoted as a certainty, for example 30% per month.
- No comprehensible explanation of where profit actually comes from, or an explanation that dissolves under a second question.
- Pressure to reinvest rather than withdraw.

WHAT TO DO

- Ask one question and insist on a real answer: where does the profit come from, specifically? Not 'trading', not 'forex', but who pays it and for what.
- Check the FSCA register. Any entity taking deposits or giving advice must be licensed.
- Treat the fact that a friend got paid as evidence of nothing. Early payouts are the mechanism, not proof of legitimacy.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/ponzi-and-pyramid-schemes/

BANK IMPERSONATION PHONE CALLS

A calm, professional caller claiming to be your bank's fraud department talks you through 'securing' your money, which means moving it to them.

85

SEVERE THREAT

R5 000–R400 000

HOW IT RUNS

1. **They already know things about you.**
Your name, your bank, the last four digits of your card, maybe a recent genuine transaction.
2. **They put you on their side.** The framing is crucial: they are not asking you for anything, they are helping you stop a fraud that is happening right now.
3. **Verification theatre.** They may invite you to hang up and call back, then keep the line open, or tell you to check that the number matches the one on the bank's website.
4. **The safe account.** The core move.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Any mention of a 'safe account', 'holding account' or 'secure account'. This concept does not exist in banking.
- A request for an OTP, PIN, password, or for you to approve something in your app while they wait.
- A request to install remote access software of any kind.
- They discourage you from hanging up, or stay on the line 'for your security'.

WHAT TO DO

- Adopt one unbreakable habit: end every unexpected financial call and phone back on the number on your card. A genuine bank will not object.
- Wait five minutes and use a different phone before calling back, or dial a known contact first to confirm the line has cleared. Attackers can hold a line open.
- Say out loud, every time: 'no bank asks for OTPs and no bank has a safe account'.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/vishing-bank-impersonation/

FAKE ONLINE STORES & SOCIAL MEDIA SHOPS

A convincing storefront with unbeatable prices takes your EFT and either sends nothing, sends a counterfeit, or vanishes the moment orders slow down.



HOW IT RUNS

1. **Paid ads do the work.** Fake stores buy Facebook, Instagram and TikTok ads.
2. **The price is the hook.** 40 to 70% below market on items that are never discounted, often with a 'closing down' or 'liquidation' story to explain it.
3. **EFT only, or EFT preferred.** Card payments and legitimate gateways can be reversed and require verified merchant accounts.
4. **Delivery is always almost happening.** Tracking numbers that do not resolve, courier delays, customs holds.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Payment by EFT to a personal account, or a business account whose name does not match the shop.
- No physical address, no landline, and contact only through a WhatsApp number or DMs.
- The domain was registered very recently, or the store has no history before its first ad.
- Reviews are all five stars, posted in a short burst, and generic.

WHAT TO DO

- Pay by card or a reputable payment gateway, never a direct EFT to a stranger. Card payments give you a dispute route; an EFT gives you nothing.
- Search the store name plus the word 'scam' before ordering, and check how long its social page has existed.
- Do a reverse image search on the product photos. Stolen imagery is the fastest tell.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/fake-online-store/

FAKE JOB OFFERS & RECRUITMENT FEES

A job that does not exist is used to extract registration fees, training costs, uniform deposits or your identity documents.



HOW IT RUNS

1. **The advert looks institutional.** Posted on a real job board, or circulated on WhatsApp with a government department, retailer or mine's logo.
2. **You are selected quickly.** Often without a real interview, or after a short WhatsApp 'interview'.
3. **A small fee appears.** Registration, criminal check, medical, uniform, training material, courier of the contract.
4. **Documents are collected.** ID copy, proof of address, bank statement, sometimes a selfie holding your ID.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Any payment required to get a job. Legitimate employers and registered agencies never charge candidates.
- Hired without a proper interview, or interviewed only over WhatsApp text.
- The email address is a free webmail account rather than a company domain.
- The role involves receiving money into your account and forwarding it. That is money laundering and you are the one who gets prosecuted.

WHAT TO DO

- Hold one rule absolutely: you never pay to be employed. Not for training, uniforms, checks or courier fees.
- Verify the employer through their official website or switchboard, never through contact details in the advert.
- Watermark any ID copy you send with the purpose and date so it cannot be reused elsewhere.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/fake-job-offer/

SASSA & SOCIAL GRANT SCAMS

Fraudsters exploit grant applicants and recipients with fake approvals, fake status checks and fees for a service that is free.



HOW IT RUNS

1. **A fee for something free.** Agents at pension points or on WhatsApp offer to 'fast-track' or 'guarantee' an application for R100 to R500.
2. **Fake status-check sites.** Lookalike websites and WhatsApp numbers ask for your ID number and phone number to 'check your status'.
3. **Banking details are changed.** With enough of your information, the payment destination is switched to a fraudster's account.
4. **Fake approval and increase messages.** SMSes announce an approved grant or a special increase, and require a small 'activation' or 'card replacement' payment, or an OTP.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Anyone charging a fee for a SASSA application, appeal or status check.
- Being asked for your SASSA card PIN or an OTP by anyone at all, including someone in a uniform or a bib.
- A message about an increase or approval that requires a payment or a click.
- Someone offering to 'help' at the machine and taking the card out of your hand.

WHAT TO DO

- Apply and check status only through official SASSA channels, and only by typing the address yourself.
- Never pay anyone for a grant service. There is no fast-track, and anyone claiming one is committing fraud.
- Never share your PIN or hand your card to anyone, including people who appear to be officials.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/sassa-grant-scam/

ROMANCE & RELATIONSHIP SCAMS

A months-long relationship is manufactured so that a series of emergencies, and eventually an investment, can be funded by you.

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SEVERE THREAT

R15 000–R1 200 000

HOW IT RUNS

1. **A profile built for you.** Photographs are stolen, usually from a real person's social media, often someone in the military, on an oil rig, or working abroad.
2. **Intensity, fast.** Contact is constant and the emotional escalation is rapid.
3. **The first small crisis.** A phone that broke, customs duty, a medical bill for a child.
4. **Escalation.** The amounts grow.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- They can never video call properly, or the camera is always broken, dark or brief.
- They profess deep feelings unusually early and message constantly.
- They move you off the dating platform quickly.
- Every planned meeting collapses at the last moment, often with a cost attached.

WHAT TO DO

- Reverse image search every profile photo. Stolen images are the most common single tell and take thirty seconds to check.
- Insist on a live video call early. Not a recording, not a photo, a call where you can ask them to do something specific.
- Set an absolute rule: no money to anyone you have not met in person. No exceptions, no matter the story.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/romance-scam/

WHATSAPP ACCOUNT HIJACKING

Someone tricks you into forwarding your WhatsApp verification code, takes over your account, and then scams your contacts while pretending to be you.



HOW IT RUNS

1. **The code request.** A message from a contact, whose account is already stolen, says they accidentally sent their verification code to your number and asks you to forward it.
2. **The takeover.** Forwarding those six digits registers your WhatsApp on their device.
3. **They become you.** They message your contacts in your voice.
4. **Group amplification.** In family, church and school groups, one hijacked account can reach hundreds of people who have no reason to doubt the sender.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Anyone asking you to forward a code you received, for any reason. WhatsApp codes are never meant for another person.
- A contact suddenly messaging from a new number and asking for money.
- Urgency plus a request to keep it quiet, or an unwillingness to take a phone call.
- Writing style that is subtly off, or the absence of shared history in the conversation.

WHAT TO DO

- Turn on WhatsApp two-step verification now. It adds a PIN that a hijacker cannot obtain from an SMS, and it is the single most effective defence.
- Never forward a verification code to anyone, including someone who appears to be a close friend.
- Agree a family rule: any request for money over WhatsApp is confirmed by voice call before anyone pays.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/whatsapp-account-hijack/

PARCEL & COURIER DELIVERY SCAMS

A message about a parcel you may or may not be expecting asks for a small fee, and harvests your card details in the process.



HOW IT RUNS

1. **A plausible interruption.** An SMS, WhatsApp or email claims a delivery failed, is held at customs, or needs an address confirmation.
2. **A trivially small fee.** R7.50, R32, R59.
3. **A convincing payment page.** The page is a clone of a courier or postal service checkout.
4. **The real charge comes later.** The small fee may never be taken at all.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- A delivery message for a parcel you cannot specifically identify.
- Any fee requested by SMS link rather than at the point of purchase.
- The link domain is not the courier's real website.
- A full card number and CVV requested for a payment of a few rand.

WHAT TO DO

- Never pay a delivery fee from a link. Go to the courier's website yourself, or to the retailer you actually ordered from, and check the order there.
- Read the content of every OTP message before entering it. The amount and merchant are stated, and they will not match.
- Use a virtual or low-limit card for online shopping so exposure is capped.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/parcel-delivery-scam/

SARS & TAX REFUND SCAMS

Emails and SMSes impersonating SARS offer a refund or threaten an audit, to capture eFiling credentials or banking details.

75

HIGH THREAT

R2 000–R300 000

HOW IT RUNS

1. **Timed to the season.** Volume spikes during filing season when a message from SARS is entirely expected and a refund is plausible.
2. **Reward or threat.** Two scripts dominate: a refund of a specific, believable amount awaiting your banking details, or a notice of audit and penalties requiring immediate login.
3. **A cloned eFiling login.** The link opens a copy of the eFiling portal.
4. **Details are changed quietly.** Inside the profile, banking details and the registered contact address are changed, so future correspondence and refunds go to them.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- An email or SMS with a link to log into eFiling. Always navigate to the site yourself instead.
- A refund amount quoted before you have submitted or been assessed.
- Threats of immediate arrest, penalty or account freezing. SARS follows formal, documented processes.
- The sender domain is not the official SARS domain, or uses a lookalike with extra words.

WHAT TO DO

- Never log into eFiling from a link. Type the address yourself or use the official app, every time.
- Set up and check your eFiling profile's registered banking and contact details periodically.
- Treat urgency and threats as evidence of fraud rather than of officialdom.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/sars-refund-scam/

FAKE RENTAL & ACCOMMODATION LISTINGS

A property that is not available, or not theirs to let, is advertised cheaply to collect deposits from multiple hopeful tenants.



HOW IT RUNS

1. **Real photographs, wrong seller.** Images are lifted from a genuine listing on a property portal, or from a legitimate sale listing, and reposted at a below-market rent.
2. **A reason they cannot meet.** The landlord is working abroad, currently in another province, or the agent is handling a portfolio remotely.
3. **Competition manufactured.** You are told several people are interested and the deposit secures it.
4. **Deposit before keys.** Payment is requested by EFT to secure the place, sometimes with a professional-looking lease sent first to build confidence.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Rent noticeably below comparable properties in the same area.
- You cannot view the property in person before paying anything.
- The landlord or agent will not do a video call from inside the property.
- Pressure to pay a deposit today to secure it.

WHAT TO DO

- Never pay a deposit for a property you or someone you trust has not physically stood inside.
- Reverse image search the listing photographs. Duplicated images across listings is the clearest single tell.
- Verify the agent's registration and Fidelity Fund Certificate with the PPRA before paying.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/fake-rental-listings/

ADVANCE FEE LOAN SCAMS

A guaranteed loan, no credit check, requires an upfront fee that you pay and a loan that never arrives.



HOW IT RUNS

1. **Advertised where desperation lives.**
Lamp poles, WhatsApp broadcasts, Facebook groups and SMS blasts.
2. **Approval without assessment.** You are approved within minutes for an amount you did not really justify.
3. **The fee, framed as standard.** An initiation fee, an insurance premium, a legal or administration charge, payable before the loan is released.
4. **It escalates.** Once the first fee is paid, a second is required: a compliance charge, a clearance fee, a bank verification deposit.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Any fee payable before a loan is disbursed.
- 'Blacklisted welcome' or 'no credit check' promises. Registered credit providers must run affordability checks by law.
- The lender is not registered with the National Credit Regulator, or quotes an NCR number that does not check out.
- Contact only through WhatsApp or a cellphone number, with no physical office.

WHAT TO DO

- Verify every lender on the NCR register before any contact. It is free and takes a minute.
- Hold the line: legitimate lenders deduct fees from the loan amount and never require a payment first.
- Understand that 'blacklisted welcome' is not a service offering, it is a filter for finding vulnerable people.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/advance-fee-loan-scam/

DEEPPFAKE CELEBRITY ENDORSEMENT ADS

AI-generated video of a well-known South African business figure or broadcaster appears to endorse a trading platform that does not exist.

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SEVERE THREAT

R4 000–R800 000

HOW IT RUNS

1. **A face you trust, saying words they never said.** Video of prominent South African business people, broadcasters and news anchors is cloned with AI.
2. **A cloned news environment.** The ad leads to a page styled as a real news publication, complete with masthead, bylines and comment sections, all fabricated.
3. **A very low entry point.** The pitch is a small starting deposit and a state-backed or bank-backed 'wealth programme'.
4. **The account manager calls.** Within minutes of registering, a professional caller takes over.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- A celebrity or public figure endorsing a specific trading platform in a social media ad. Real endorsements do not run this way.
- A 'news article' whose links all lead to the same signup form.
- Claims of government, Reserve Bank or major bank backing for a private trading scheme.
- You are phoned within minutes of registering, by someone very good at their job.

WHAT TO DO

- Treat every celebrity investment endorsement in a social feed as fake by default. Prominent South Africans have publicly disclaimed these ads repeatedly.
- Check the FSCA register before depositing anything, without exception.
- Look at the video closely: hands, teeth, blinking and the edges of the jaw are still where AI generation breaks down.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/deepfake-celebrity-endorsement/

ATM CARD SWAPPING & SKIMMING

Your card is jammed, distracted away from you, or physically substituted at an ATM while your PIN is observed.



HOW IT RUNS

1. **The machine is prepared.** A thin device or strip is placed in the card slot so the card is retained, or the keypad is overlaid with a skimming pad.
2. **Help arrives.** A friendly stranger appears immediately, having watched you struggle.
3. **The switch.** In the confusion your card is returned to you, except it is a different card of the same bank.
4. **Immediate use.** Withdrawals and purchases begin within minutes, usually at a different centre and before the loss is noticed.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Anyone offering unsolicited help at an ATM, however respectable they appear.
- The card slot looks loose, thicker than usual, or has visible glue or residue.
- The keypad feels raised, spongy or slightly misaligned.
- Someone standing closer than necessary, or two people working the queue together.

WHAT TO DO

- Accept help from nobody at an ATM. Not a security guard, not a bank-branded shirt, not a kind stranger. Use the intercom or go inside the branch.
- Cover the keypad completely with your other hand, every time.
- Inspect the card slot and keypad before inserting. Give the slot a gentle tug.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/atm-card-swap/

TECH SUPPORT & REMOTE ACCESS SCAMS

A fake technician convinces you your device is infected or that you are owed a refund, then uses remote access to take money directly.



HOW IT RUNS

1. **Alarm arrives.** A full-screen browser pop-up with sirens and a warning number, or a cold call claiming your machine is sending errors to Microsoft.
2. **Remote access is granted.** You are guided to install AnyDesk, TeamViewer or similar.
3. **Fake evidence.** Ordinary system logs are shown as proof of infection, or a command window is used to display alarming but meaningless text.
4. **Payment or the refund trick.** Either you pay for worthless 'protection', or, in the more expensive version, they claim to have refunded you too much.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- An unsolicited call about your computer. Microsoft, Apple and your ISP do not phone you about infections.
- A pop-up with a phone number. Real security software never asks you to call anyone.
- Any request to install remote access software.
- Being asked to log into online banking while someone is connected to your machine.

WHAT TO DO

- Never install remote access software because an inbound caller asked you to.
- Close alarming pop-ups by force-quitting the browser. Never phone the number displayed.
- If someone claims to have refunded you, log out, close everything, and check the balance in your banking app independently.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/tech-support-scam/

SEXTORTION & BLACKMAIL SCAMS

A threat to publish intimate images, real or entirely invented, is used to extract escalating payments.

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ELEVATED THREAT

R500–R80 000

HOW IT RUNS

1. **Contact and rapid escalation.** An attractive stranger makes contact on Instagram, Snapchat, a dating app or Facebook, and moves quickly to intimate conversation and video.
2. **Material is captured.** The video call is recorded, or images are requested and saved.
3. **The demand.** Within minutes, contact turns to threat, usually with a screenshot of your friends list to show they know exactly who would receive it.
4. **It never ends with one payment.** Paying confirms you can be pressured.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- A new online contact who escalates to intimate video unusually fast.
- They push to a platform where video can be recorded, and steer the conversation quickly.
- An immediate threat with a short deadline and a demand in crypto, gift cards or e-wallet transfer.
- An email quoting a password you recognise from years ago. That is from a public breach, not from your device.

WHAT TO DO

- Never share intimate images or perform on video with someone you have not met in person, however genuine they seem.
- Lock down your friends and followers lists. Leverage in this scam comes from visible contacts.
- Understand in advance that paying makes it worse, not better. Decide this now, not in the panic.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/sextortion-scam/

MUNICIPAL, ESKOM & PREPAID ELECTRICITY SCAMS

Fake disconnection notices, bogus meter technicians and discounted electricity tokens exploit anxiety about utility accounts.



HOW IT RUNS

1. **The disconnection threat.** An SMS, call or a person at the gate claims disconnection is imminent unless immediate payment is made, often demanding cash or an EFT to a personal account.
2. **The fake technician.** Someone in overalls with a clipboard arrives to 'inspect' or 'upgrade' the meter, charges a fee, and in some cases uses the visit to case the property.
3. **Discounted tokens.** Prepaid electricity is offered at 40 to 60% off, sold through WhatsApp groups.
4. **The consequence lands later.** Fraudulent tokens are traceable.

HOW YOU SPOT IT

- Payment demanded in cash, or by EFT to a personal account rather than the municipality's official account.
- A technician who arrives unannounced and has no verifiable work order or identification you can check by phone.
- Prepaid electricity offered below the regulated price. There is no legitimate discount on prepaid tokens.
- Threat of disconnection today, with no prior written notice on your account.

WHAT TO DO

- Pay only through official municipal channels, using the account details on your statement.
- Phone the municipality on their published number to verify any disconnection notice or scheduled visit.
- Never let an unverified 'technician' near your meter or into your property.

Full breakdown:

isitascam.co.za/scams/municipal-utility-scam/

TAKE THIS AWAY

RULES WITH NO EXCEPTIONS

No bank, ever, asks for your OTP, PIN or password. There is no exception and no emergency that creates one.

There is no such thing as a safe account, a holding account or a suspense account you must move your money into.

You never pay a fee to receive money. Not a prize, not a refund, not a loan, not an inheritance, not your own investment profits.

You never pay to be given a job.

Never forward a verification code to anyone, including someone who appears to be a close friend.

Never install remote access software because an inbound caller asked you to.

Never send money to someone you have not met in person.

Any change of banking details, on any invoice, from anyone, is verified by voice call on a number you already had.

Caller ID, sender IDs, logos, https padlocks and five-star reviews are all trivially faked. None of them is verification.

Anyone who contacts you offering to recover money you have already lost is scamming you again.

IF IT HAS ALREADY HAPPENED

REPORT IT, IN THIS ORDER

1. **Phone your bank's fraud line.** From the number on your bank card, not one from a message. Do this within minutes, not hours. Speed is the single biggest factor in whether money is recovered.
2. **Freeze or block.** Freeze cards and accounts in the banking app while you wait to be answered. You can always unfreeze.
3. **Change passwords from a clean device.** Start with the email account that can reset everything else. Use a device that was not involved in the incident.
4. **Open a SAPS case.** Go to any police station and get a case number. Your bank, insurer and credit providers will ask for it.
5. **Preserve the evidence.** Screenshot chats, profiles, emails, payment confirmations, URLs, wallet addresses and phone numbers before anything is deleted.
6. **Refuse all recovery offers.** Anyone who contacts you afterwards offering to recover your money is running the second half of the scam.

Full reporting guide, including which body handles which type of fraud: isitascam.co.za/report/

LOOK IT UP BEFORE YOU PAY.

32 scams, scored and explained, free and open to everyone.

ISITASCAM.CO.ZA